

Hoofed mammals

Hooves are simply enlarged toenails that support an animal's weight and help it walk on hard ground. All hoofed mammals evolved from ancestors with five toes, but over time some toes withered away, leaving just one, two, or three main hooves per foot. Early hoofed mammals were as small as cats, but later species grew to a huge size on a diet of grass or leaves.



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- Most were plant eaters
- Walked and ran on four legs
- Toes with hooves
- Large teeth to grind vegetation; some also had tusks
- Some had horns

When

Hoofed mammals first appeared in the Paleogene Period (about 65 million years ago). Most lived in forests or grasslands.

Y-shaped horns with blunt ends, which may have been used for display

Megacerops

MEG-a-SEH-rops



- **When** 38–30 million years ago (Paleogene)
- **Fossil location** N. America, Asia
- **Habitat** Plains
- **Length** 10 ft (3 m)
- **Diet** Plants

When Native Americans of the Sioux tribe in the United States found the huge fossilized bones of *Megacerops* in the ground, they thought they were the remains of mythical creatures that galloped across the clouds causing storms, and so named them “thunder horses.” *Megacerops* was indeed a relative of the horse, but in build and size it was more like a modern rhinoceros and was probably covered in thick hide. The bones above its shoulders bore long spines to support its huge neck muscles and heavy head.

Feeding habits

Megacerops's teeth suggest it ate soft plants rather than rough vegetation. It may have had a long tongue and flexible lips to choose plants with care.

